CHAPTER 3 | **SCALING THE WALL**

Shinkichi Tajiri, Exiled Sculpture, and the Reconstruction of the Berlin Wall

> At its center a violent, lethal non-place; an alluring, pitiless obstacle course; a forbidden zone with nothing but the silence before the shot. The actual designers were no longer in control of the architectural result of their work. … The Wall enjoyed a career as a thing of its own making.
> —OLAF BRIESE

Within a decade of the initial construction of the Berlin Wall, the sprawling barricade aimed at keeping intact both the social vision and the citizenry of the German Democratic Republic, the ruling regime eyed improvements to its border system. The GDR intended to secure the permanence and elevate the esteem of the infamous structure. Sculptor Shinkichi Tajiri, a newcomer to West Berlin in 1969, was compelled by the Wall's vast footprint and uneven surfaces under revision. The renovations of the late 1960s and early 1970s meant that the Wall, by design, would be in a state of constant change for several years. As the period of détente with the West unfolded, GDR officials tinkered with the massive overhaul of their byzantine border. They ordered reconstruction of the wall system through a "robust mandate" to address the structural and aesthetic concerns over a border wall that had been hastily constructed, improvised even at its most significant and visible locations. Olaf Briese cites a 1965 internal document from the city command that stated, "The technical barriers are non-standard and maintenance intensive. … They often do not increase the prestige of the German Democratic Republic on the world stage."[1] In addressing such concerns, the GDR aimed to remedy the function as well as the aesthetic reputation of a border wall that from its beginnings was as unwieldy as it was menacing, with built components placed clumsily in the interest of expediency. Briese explains that the East German regime carried out this first round of extensive revisions in the late 1960s and early 1970s, during which "the wall became the foremost element of a refined, graduated barrier system: an interior wall, a border alarm fence, antitank barricades, dog-patrolled areas (mainly on the edges of Berlin), observations towers, light arrays, patrol paths, plowed or